How to reset your password with self-service password reset (SSPR)

Article KB0010001 | Owner: Service Desk L1 | Subcategory: Password reset | Applies to: Windows 11 (23H2/24H2) on Dell Latitude/Lenovo ThinkPad/HP EliteBook, macOS 14/15 on MacBook Pro/Air, Any device that authenticates via Azure AD/On-prem AD for Acme Global resources, VPN (Palo Alto GlobalProtect), Microsoft 365 services (Outlook, Teams, OneDrive)

Summary

This article explains how Acme Global employees can reset their domain password using the self-service password reset (SSPR) portal. It covers prerequisites, step-by-step instructions for end-users, and the corresponding procedure for Service Desk L1 agents when users cannot complete SSPR on their own. Follow the guidance to regain access to Windows, macOS, VPN, and Microsoft 365 resources while staying within company password policy.

Symptoms

- "The username or password is incorrect."
- "Your password has expired and must be changed."
- "Account locked because of too many failed sign-in attempts."
- "Unable to connect to VPN - cached credentials are outdated."
- "Did not receive the password reset verification email/SMS."
- "New password does not meet complexity requirements."

Common causes

- Forgotten or expired password.
- Account lockout after 5 failed attempts (15-minute lockout).
- Cached credentials not updated after password change.
- Missing or expired authentication method (phone, authenticator app) for SSPR.
- Password does not meet 14-character minimum, history, or complexity rules.
- Network connectivity issues preventing reach of https://passwordreset.acme.example.

Overview

Acme Global provides a self-service password reset (SSPR) portal that lets users change or unlock their Active Directory/Azure AD password without contacting the Service Desk. The portal is available at https://passwordreset.acme.example and uses the same verification methods you have registered for multi-factor authentication (Microsoft Authenticator push, SMS, or alternate email). Successful reset updates your password for Windows login, macOS login, VPN, and all Microsoft 365 services.

Before you begin

To use SSPR you need:

- Access to the internet and a web browser.
- Your Acme Global user ID (your full email address, e.g., john.doe@acme.example).
- At least one verification method that you have previously registered in Azure AD (Microsoft Authenticator app, SMS-capable phone number, or alternate email address).

If you cannot reach any of your registered verification methods, you will need to contact the Service Desk for a Temporary Access Pass (TAP) before proceeding.

Reset your password using the self-service portal

Follow these steps to reset your password yourself. The process takes only a few minutes and will immediately allow you to sign in to your corporate resources.

1. Open a web browser and go to https://passwordreset.acme.example.
2. Enter your Acme Global user ID (your full email address) and click **Next**.
3. Choose a verification method: Microsoft Authenticator push notification, SMS to your registered mobile number, or email to your alternate email address.
4. Approve the verification: tap **Approve** in the Authenticator app, or enter the code sent by SMS/email and click **Next**.

5. You will now be prompted to create a new password. Type a password that is at least 14 characters long, contains three of the four character types (uppercase, lowercase, number, special symbol), and has not been used in your last 10 passwords.
6. Confirm the new password by typing it again and click **Finish**.
7. A confirmation screen will appear stating "Your password has been reset." Close the browser.
8. On your Windows laptop, lock the screen (Win+L) and sign in with your new password. If you are off-campus, first connect to the VPN (GlobalProtect) so the new credentials are cached, then lock/unlock to update.
9. On macOS, lock the screen (Control+Command+Q) and log in with the new password; FileVault will sync the password automatically.
10. After logging in, open Outlook or Teams to verify that your Microsoft 365 access works and that any cached credentials in Windows Credential Manager have been updated.

Service-desk agent procedure

When a user cannot complete SSPR on their own, follow this procedure to verify identity, assist with password reset, and ensure cached credentials are cleared.

1. Verify the caller's identity using standard verification (ask for employee ID, date of birth, or request a Temporary Access Pass from the IAM team if needed).
2. Ask whether the user can access the SSPR portal. If yes, guide them through steps 1-6 of the user self-help procedure.
3. If the user cannot receive verification codes (no access to registered phone/email), work with the IAM team to issue a Temporary Access Pass (TAP) and have the user sign in at https://mysignins.microsoft.com/securityinfo to register a new authentication method.
4. Once the password has been reset via SSPR or you have reset it on the user's behalf in Azure AD, instruct the user to disconnect and reconnect to the VPN (GlobalProtect) to update cached credentials.
5. For Windows machines, clear stale credentials from Credential Manager: open a command prompt and run `cmdkey /list` to locate entries targeting `legacy:` or `domain:` and delete them with `cmdkey /delete:<target>`.
6. Confirm the user can log in locally, to VPN, Outlook, Teams, and OneDrive.
7. Close the ticket with resolution notes: method used (SSPR guided, TAP issued, password reset by agent), timestamps, and any credential-manager cleanup performed.

Verification

After completing the reset, verify that the new password works everywhere you need it. Sign in to your Windows or macOS device, connect to the VPN, and launch Outlook, Teams, and OneDrive. If any prompts for credentials appear, enter the new password. You can also check the password age in the Windows Settings > Accounts > Sign-in options or via the Azure AD portal to confirm the change was processed.

Troubleshooting

Common issues and quick fixes are listed below. If the problem persists after trying these steps, escalate to the Service Desk (or IAM for verification-method problems).

1. Did not receive verification code - check your spam/junk folder, verify that the phone number or email address in Azure AD is correct, and try an alternative verification method.
2. Password rejected - ensure the new password is at least 14 characters long, contains at least three of four character types (uppercase, lowercase, number, special symbol), and is not among your last 10 passwords.
3. Still unable to log in after reset - connect to the VPN, lock/unlock your session, clear Windows Credential Manager (see agent procedure), and reboot the computer.
4. Account shows locked - wait 15 minutes for the automatic lockout timer to expire, or ask the Service Desk to have IAM unlock the account.
5. Portal unavailable - confirm you have internet access, try from another device or network, and if the portal remains unreachable, contact the Service Desk for escalation.

When to escalate

If the user cannot complete SSPR because none of their registered verification methods are accessible, or the account

remains locked after the standard 15-minute lockout period, escalate to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team. Include the following details in the escalation: user ID (email address), description of the failure (e.g., 'no access to authenticator or SMS'), timestamp of the attempt, any error codes shown on the SSPR page, and confirmation that you have verified the user's identity via standard procedures. The IAM team can issue a Temporary Access Pass, unlock the account, or help register a new authentication method.

Keywords: password reset, SSPR, self service password reset, forgot password, expired password, account lockout, credential manager, temporary access pass, VPN cached credentials, Microsoft Authenticator, SMS verification, alternate email